



Offline: Indifference—the biggest threat to global health



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The science of global health offers reasons for great confidence about the future for human wellbeing. Implementation of the RTS,S/AS01 malaria vaccine into routine immunisation programmes is predicted to have a significant impact on child mortality. Studies suggest that hospital admissions among children with severe malaria will be cut by up to a third. A second malaria vaccine, R21/Matrix-M, is already licensed in several African countries. It has even higher protective efficacy: over 75%. Mother-to-child transmission of HIV is on the verge of being eliminated. Solar-powered oxygen systems installed in rural African settings can reduce deaths among hypoxaemic children by almost half—and the technology is extremely cost-effective. The Global Fund invests US\$5 billion annually to control HIV/AIDS, tuberculosis, and malaria. Since 1974, vaccination programmes have averted 154 million deaths. New investments in national health surveys are revealing fresh challenges that have hitherto received little international attention, such as mental ill-health. So, when Ministers of Health gather at the World Health Assembly (WHA) in Geneva later this month, they should be doing so in a mood of optimism and hope. The tools and policies available to political leaders to achieve transformations in health and health care have never been more powerful. Yet the reality is that when they assemble in the magnificent Palais des Nations ministers will be confronting an emergency far worse than the pandemic they have spent the past 4 years struggling to control—indifference.



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The world's gaze is no longer directed at health. Countries are consumed by fear and distracted by insecurity, occasioned by war, economic instability, and social precarity. Sustainable development has become nothing more than a luxurious adornment when confronting these brutal political realities. Whether elected or appointed, national leaders face the same predicament—restless citizens who see living standards threatened and their children's futures incinerated. People are raising their voices to demand action and protection. Health, whether envisioned domestically or globally, simply does not figure in the calculus of quenching this pervasive discontent. And while politicians play avoidance, there is a reckoning. In WHO's biennium results report for 2022–23, the agency

admits that, with the exception of tobacco use, none of the health-related targets of the Sustainable Development Goals will be reached at present rates of progress. WHO has made universal health coverage (UHC) its totemic signature initiative. But the agency reports that "The world is off track to meet the target of 1 billion more people benefiting from universal health coverage by 2025." What progress there has been owes much to the expansion of HIV services. WHO and the World Bank's *Tracking Universal Health Coverage 2023 Global Monitoring Report* makes for grim reading. Few countries had improved service coverage or reduced catastrophic out-of-pocket health expenditure. The gains made have now stalled. Improvements in services for non-communicable diseases and reproductive, maternal, newborn, and child health have been paltry. COVID-19 is blamed for these failures. It is fair to argue that the pandemic drew attention and resources away from other areas of health. But in the post-pandemic era, political leaders now have other issues to occupy their time. The WHO and World Bank's report painted an unusually bleak picture: "The available evidence presents a potentially dire prospect for further progress toward UHC without urgent political action."

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The fact is that there is a mismatch between opportunity and delivery. That gap is filled by a mix of apathy, disregard, and weariness with the health sector. The WHA is a curious meeting. WHO, ministers, and civil society activists will be preaching to the converted when they urge greater commitment, immediate action, and an end to the complacency about health. What is the alternative? WHO, together with its most vulnerable member states and its most powerful contributors, must strategise to devise a campaign to make health a greater global priority. This is not a zero-sum equation. More health does not mean less education. Health is foundational because it diffuses into all sectors of society and the economy. The symbiosis of health with security and prosperity makes it a catalyst for social advantage. WHO's Director-General has an opportunity to use the WHA as the starting point to begin a transformative endeavour to achieve health equity.

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